2

BECOMING THE HINDI HEARTLAND'S PREDOMINANT RURAL PARTY

The BJP has emerged as the predominant rural party in the Hindi heartland between 2014 and 2019. There is compelling evidence of this. In order to better understand the spatial geography of the party's growth, Jai Mrug, psephologist and founder of the polling agency VotersMood Research (VMR), Rishabh Srivastava and I classified 225 parliamentary constituencies in the ten Hindi-speaking states of north and central India (UP, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Delhi) into three categories: urban, rurban and rural. We did this by taking district-level census demographic data, systematically overlaying it onto Lok Sabha constituencies and geotagging them. Jai did the initial theoretical classification, defining urban seats as those with urban populations above 80 per cent, rurban as seats having an urban population between 33 and 60 per cent and rural seats as those with less than 33 per cent urban population. I did the political mapping and analysis, and Srivastava produced the data analytics. We were astonished by the patterns this exercise uncovered.

Hindi-speaking states are the central power engine of the BJP's national political dominance, accounting for almost 60 per cent of its 303-seat majority in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls. The party won over 78 per cent of the 225 Hindi heartland seats in 2019, over 84 per cent in 2014. These triumphs were essentially fashioned on the